Building a culture of tolerance and peace

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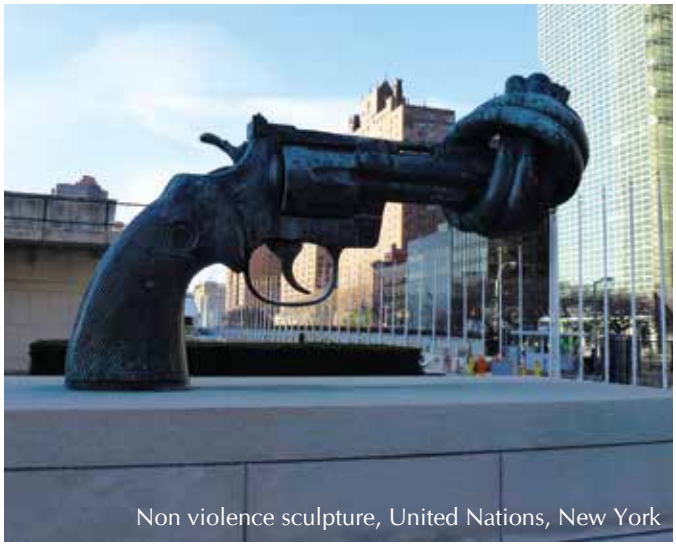

Non violence sculpture, United Nations, New York

Symbols of peace

What other symbols denote peace?

The meaning of tolerance and peace

This worksheet will explore how to bring both intellectual horsepower and emotional learning onto the same page in the Book of Life. No amount of academic knowledge can fill the spiritual space in the mind of a child. Skills and abilities should be designed to simultaneously create a climate for ethical behaviour and underscore the importance for peace in an increasingly violent world. The two are inextricably linked.

Japanese peace bell, United Nations

Peace, the lowering of temperatures when conflicts arise – and they *will* – is built on self-control and a practice of learning to understand people who look and sound different from ourselves. Their beliefs and responses will also vary from ours. The degree might vary but the point is that differences have to be managed and not reacted to roughly. This bunch of skills and social intelligence might collectively be called tolerance.

Some time ago, the Norwegian Academy of Sciences calculated that since the start of recorded history there has been only one minute of peace for every four hours of war. If life skills and values are not cultivated, a school with its intense atmosphere of competition and the need to succeed can well become, in the words of Prof. Krishna Kumar, a training ground for war. Never more than now has Maria Montessori's statement seemed truer, "All education is for peace."

Many teachers have expressed concern that students by their final school year are not made sufficiently aware of how they can improve society, given the multiple realities of the national ethos. In our multicultural and hierarchical society it would be meaningful to think of tolerance and anti-bias as an educational movement, a powerful force to build peace in all spheres of life. It will foster values, social awareness, and the requisite knowledge and skills to empower the compassionate and justice-seeking side of young adult minds.

The exercises in this worksheet will look at managing differences, identifying and stopping bullying and meanness in schools, and learning how to cope with anger, fear, and loneliness.

Ahimsa = Don't hurt

AHIMSA is a new word for you. It means don't hurt. Especially, don't hurt animals, or birds, or insects.

When you see an in your house, don't hurt it. Just sweep it away.

When you see a in your kitchen, don't hurt it. Open the window and let it go.

When you see a in your bathroom, don't hurt it. Sweep it away.

When you see a in your room, don't hurt it. Open the window and let it go.

Tick what you should do

When you see a spider?	Kill it / sweep it away.
When you see a bee?	Cry / open the window and let it go.
When you see an ant?	Stamp on it / sweep it away.

Don't hurt any living thing. They too can feel pain.

The plant is a living thing. Don't hurt it.
What can you do? Give it water / pull the leaves.

The kitten is a living thing. Don't hurt it.
What can you do? Pull its tail / give it some milk.

Be kind to your pets
Do you have a cuddly toy? Is it a doggie? Or a kitten? Or a fluffy rabbit?
Do you like cuddling it? Can your toy cuddle you back? Or wag its tail? Or mew when it sees you?
No? That's because it is not real. It is a toy. Not a pet.
When you have a pet dog, or cat, or rabbit, or bird, it is real. It is alive just like you.
Just like you, your pets can feel fear, happiness, sadness, and hunger.

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Is this dog looking hungry/sad/happy? .....
What can you do for it? I can give it a cookie / a ball/ a hug .....

Look at the boy in this picture.
Is he hurting the turtle? Yes / No
Does the turtle look happy? Yes / No

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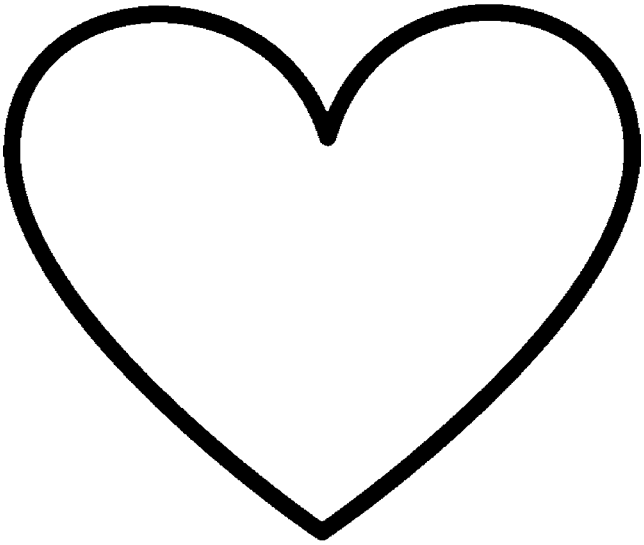
Remember! Be kind to your pets.

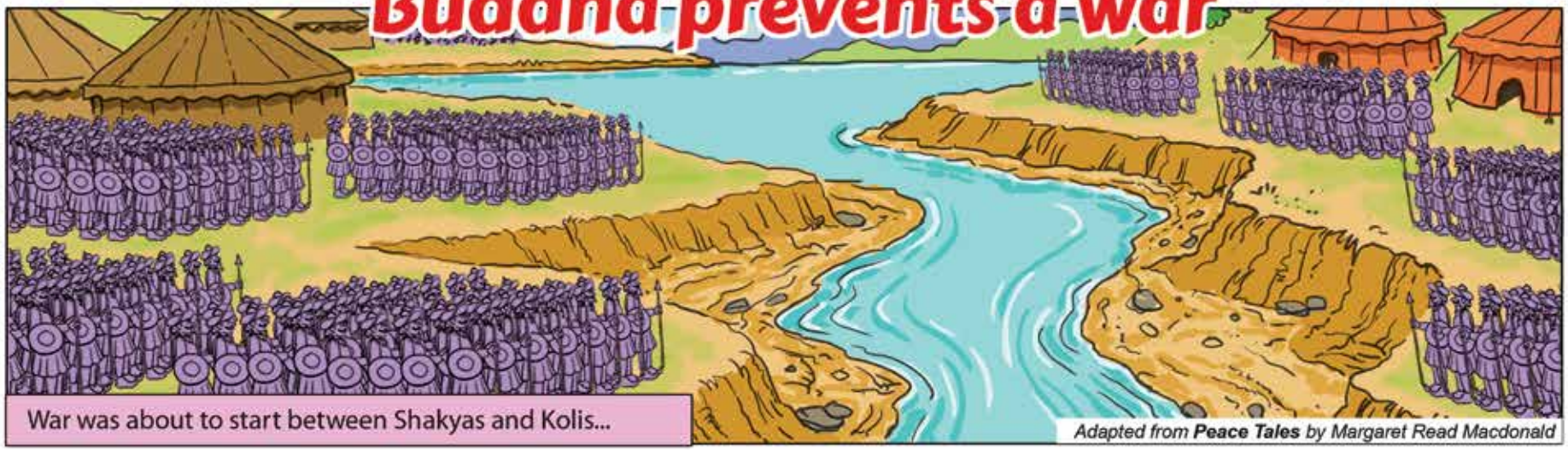
A good heart is a beautiful home where you can always find peace!

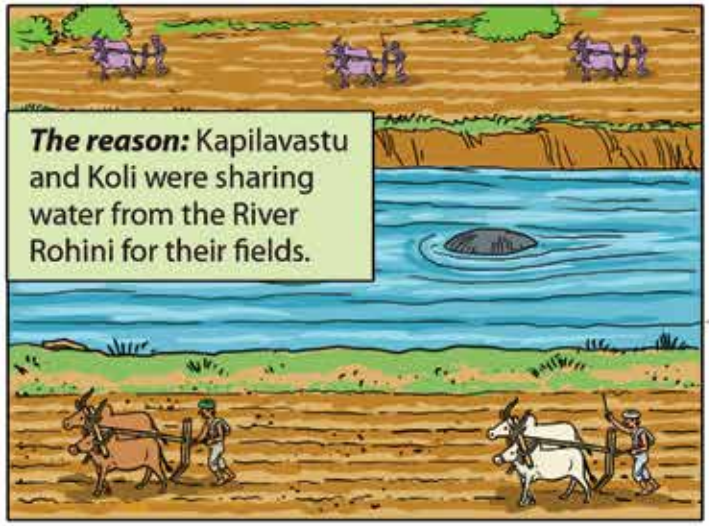
This is your heart. Write inside it five good feelings that you want to keep, and outside it, five bad feelings that you want to throw out. You can choose from the list of words given here.

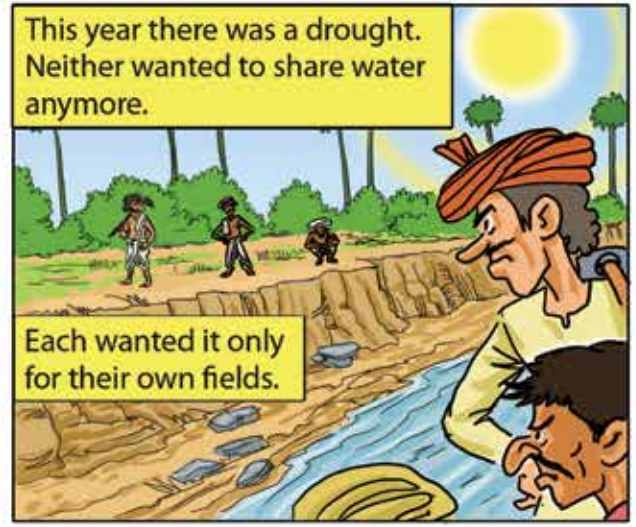
Happy, angry, mean, loving, contended, hopeful, open, cruel, sneaky, suspicious, warm, tender, selfish, bitter, sour, friendly, sweet, hateful.

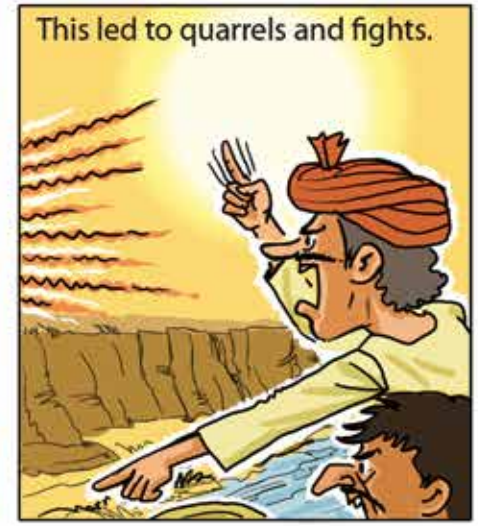


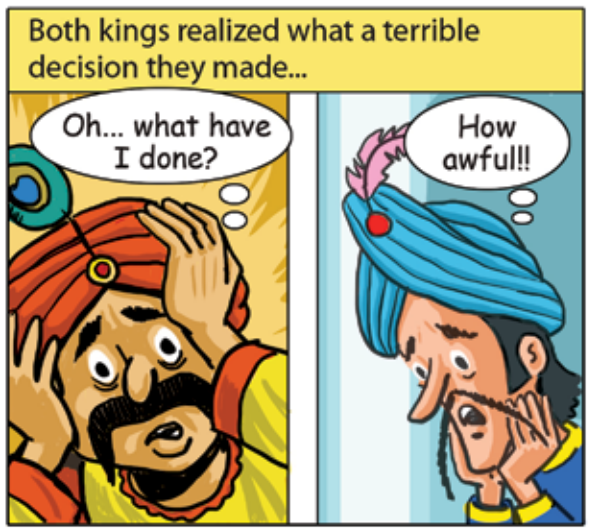
Buddha prevents a war











Let's talk it over!

- In this story, Buddha was a peacemaker. How would you explain 'peacemaker' to your friend?
- Why is peace making important? What will happen if we don't make peace with those we fight with?
- Think of some situations in class where you can be a peacemaker.

Illustration: Vincent Moses Raja

Toss away the garbage!

Imagine a child holding a big bag of garbage in both hands, so that when someone came up and offered her a flower she could not take it. Negative feelings such as anger, suspicion, and resentment are like garbage that needs to be tossed away before we can take and smell the flower of peace.

Let us remember that negative feelings block the holistic development of a child. A happy and secure child will be a better student: more respectful, willing to listen, willing to learn.

Stop bullying

Bullying is:	A bully causes:	A bully is not:
Mean	Pain	Friendly
Hurtful	Sadness	Likeable
.....	.....	.....
.....	.....	.....

Bullying destroys tolerance and peace because:

_____

_____

_____

Have you ever bullied anyone?	YES	NO
Have you ever been bullied?	YES	NO
Have you ever tried to stop a bully?	YES	NO

Bullying is not a flaw in character. It is a bad habit. A bully can be taught how to stop.

CLASS PLEDGE
WE WILL NEVER BULLY OTHERS. WE WILL STOP OTHERS FROM BULLYING.

Tolerance is the doorway to peace

November 16 every year is celebrated as The International Year of Tolerance.

TOLERANCE is particularly important in India because we have great diversity.

And people belonging to different faiths live here.

Tolerance means RESPECT for people's feelings, opinions, and beliefs.
Tolerance means ACCEPTANCE of differences in culture, language, religion, and abilities.
Tolerance means UNDERSTANDING the other person's needs and rights.

Why does greater diversity call for greater tolerance?

_____

Think of three ways in which tolerance promotes peace.

1 _____

2 _____

3 _____

Create a tolerance postage stamp for International Day of Tolerance.

Sharing and caring

Sharing and caring bring happiness and peace

Source: www.pixabay.com

Choose names for these children.

Girl: .....

Boy: .....

What is the boy telling his sister?

.....

What will the girl say to her brother?

.....

Write three lines about how sharing and caring bring happiness and peace

_____

_____

_____

Peace means making others happy

If we have no PEACE it is because we have forgotten that we belong to each other – ***Mother Teresa***

Who was Mother Teresa?

_____

How did she promote tolerance and peace?

_____

What is meant by 'we belong to each other'?

_____

Self-control is a life skill

Imagine that in your journey through life, **your mind is a car**. You are the driver. The roads, road surfaces, obstacles, hold-ups are life events that are beyond your control. You have to follow many **road rules**.

If everyone drives properly, traffic flows smoothly.
If we all learn how to control our anger, all our lives will be more peaceful and harmonious.

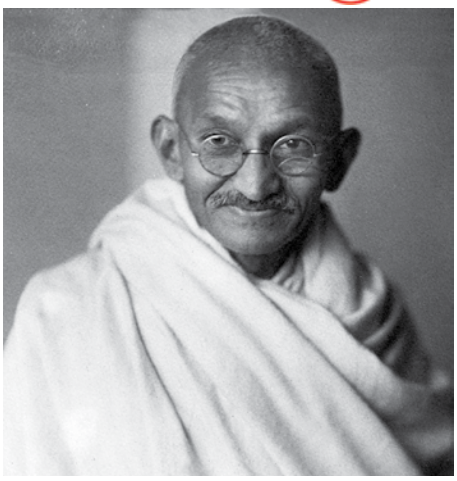
So you must control your car. You must learn how to turn away from hitting against other cars. You must learn when to apply the brake.

When we learn how to control our anger and negative emotions, life becomes smoother and more enjoyable on the road of life.

How good are you as a 'driver'?
(a) I can control my anger well
(b) I sometimes lose my temper and say rude things
(c) I lose my temper very often.

What can you do to become a better 'driver'? _____

SAY NO! TO VIOLENCE OF EVERY KIND



Peace is its own reward – ***Mahatma Gandhi***

Write a few lines about Mahatma Gandhi's idea of AHIMSA

_____

_____

_____

_____

HAPPINESS IS PEACE. PEACE IS HAPPINESS

HAPPINESS IS A STATE OF MIND...NOT OF MATERIAL COMFORT

IT DEPENDS ON PEACE...NOT ON MONEY

Create your own design with the words PEACE and HAPPINESS written inside

Decorate and colour this poster

Developed by Peace Education Team, authors of Living in Harmony (Oxford University Press). They can be reached at <minikrishnan51@gmail.com>.